

Start with the work, not the AI tool

Mandate: identify useful automation opportunities inside an enterprise IT scrum team.

I met individually with the enterprise architect, business analyst, scrum master and operations analyst to understand their responsibilities, recurring work and bottlenecks. I organized those inputs into personas, problem statements and a first-workflow assessment.

01

1:1 interviews

Semi-structured: goals, decisions, workarounds and exceptions.

Interview notes

02

Workflow walkthrough

Follow a recent case from intake to handoff. Separate work from waiting.

Current-state workflow map

03

Affinity mapping

Group recurring issues. Separate symptoms from possible causes.

Personas + pain-point register

04

Compare opportunities

Assess value, readiness and control needs before selecting a pilot.

Scorecard + pilot brief

PRACTICAL DISCOVERY TOOLKIT

Interviews	Approved call + notes	Recent cases, decisions and constraints
Map + synthesize	Miro / diagrams.net	Handoffs, missing inputs and decisions
Evidence + scoring	Excel / Sheets	Sample ID, pain point, impact and rationale

Tools are options within the approved enterprise workspace.

Methods: [1] [2] [3] [9] [10] [11] | References on page 11

BUSINESS ALIGNMENT

Recover capacity for higher-value work.
Reduce handoff delays and rework.
Keep accountability and review visible.

Enterprise architect

Protect architecture capacity by getting each request to the right owner with enough context to act.



INTERVIEW SUMMARY

Paraphrased

“Every request still needs someone to read it and decide which architect should pick it up.”

ROLE GOAL

Spend more time on architecture decisions and less on directing incoming work.

WORKFLOW CONTEXT

Reviews architecture requests, identifies the relevant domain and coordinates specialist input when work crosses boundaries.

REPORTED BOTTLENECK

Too many incoming requests require manual review and assignment to the correct enterprise architect.

CONTRIBUTING FACTORS TO VALIDATE

Incomplete intake

Missing service, business objective, sponsor or deadline may trigger clarification before work can start.

Cross-domain ownership

Security, data and application concerns can overlap. A primary owner may be unclear even when the topic is classified.

Repeated handoffs

Forwarded threads and changing owners may make queue status, accountability and response delays hard to trace.

EVIDENCE TO COLLECT Recent requests • final owner • reassignment history • missing fields • time to accepted ownership

USER NEEDS

A consistent intake brief; a primary owner with a reason for the match; visibility into unassigned and aging requests.

ADOPTION & CONTROL NEEDS

Architects must be able to correct ownership. The workflow should suggest a route, not make architecture decisions or broadcast sensitive requests.

PROBLEM DEFINITION

Manual request assignment delays ownership and consumes architecture capacity. Standardized intake and explainable routing are the first improvement, before any autonomous action.

Business analyst

Protect analysis time while keeping incoming support requests, priorities and ownership visible.



INTERVIEW SUMMARY

Paraphrased

“Before I can work on the issue, I have to read the email, work out what it needs and find the right team.”

ROLE GOAL

Move routine intake quickly without losing urgent work or spending the day sorting messages.

WORKFLOW CONTEXT

Receives support-team emails, interprets the request, clarifies missing details and coordinates the next action with the owning team.

REPORTED BOTTLENECK

Growing support-email volume has made manual reading, classification and routing a bottleneck.

CONTRIBUTING FACTORS TO VALIDATE

Mixed requests

One message may contain several issues. A single label can hide a secondary action or send part of the work to the wrong owner.

Missing thread context

Follow-ups such as “any update?” may be impossible to classify safely from the latest message alone.

Priority and reply quality

Polite language can still describe an urgent deadline. Drafts also need approved wording and should not promise an unverified resolution.

EVIDENCE TO COLLECT De-identified emails • category/owner labels • active handling time • thread gaps • urgency decisions

USER NEEDS

A concise request summary; a suggested type, priority and owner; the source message; and a visible exception queue for ambiguous cases.

ADOPTION & CONTROL NEEDS

The analyst retains review and override. Receiving teams agree category ownership. No automatic external replies or actions based only on a model confidence score.

PROBLEM DEFINITION

Growing email intake consumes analyst capacity before substantive work begins. A human-reviewed triage workflow can standardize intake while preserving urgency, context and ownership.

Scrum master

Turn agreed team actions into reviewable tickets without repeated transcription or invented detail.



INTERVIEW SUMMARY

Paraphrased

“After the meeting, I still have to turn the discussion into tickets and check that the details and owners are right.”

ROLE GOAL

Keep the backlog ready for delivery while spending less time re-entering meeting outcomes.

WORKFLOW CONTEXT

Coordinates team ceremonies, follows up on actions and supports the creation of actionable work items in the team backlog.

REPORTED BOTTLENECK

Too much time is spent manually creating tickets from team discussions and other working inputs.

CONTRIBUTING FACTORS TO VALIDATE

Scattered source material

Actions may be split across meeting notes, chat and documents. It can be difficult to trace a ticket back to the agreed decision.

Unresolved ticket fields

An owner, due date or acceptance criterion may not have been agreed. Filling the template must not create a false commitment.

Rework and duplicates

An action may already exist in the backlog, or a new draft may need several edits before it is ready for review.

EVIDENCE TO COLLECT Meeting notes • accepted tickets • required fields • draft-to-accept time • corrections and duplicates

USER NEEDS

A draft in the correct ticket format; a source reference; visible missing fields; and one review step before anything enters the live backlog.

ADOPTION & CONTROL NEEDS

The scrum master reviews drafts with the relevant team member. Do not assign estimates, owners, sprint commitments or acceptance criteria without confirmation.

PROBLEM DEFINITION

Manual transcription turns ticket creation into coordination overhead. The first improvement is source-linked drafting with required-field checks, not autonomous backlog management.

Operations analyst

Make invoices and related messages easier to sort, track and send to the correct reviewer.



INTERVIEW SUMMARY

Paraphrased

“I open the email and its attachments just to work out what document it is, what is missing and where it should go.”

ROLE GOAL

Keep document intake moving and surface exceptions before they create repeated follow-up.

WORKFLOW CONTEXT

Reviews operational emails and invoices, identifies the document and routes it to the appropriate business or finance reviewer.

REPORTED BOTTLENECK

Invoices and related emails are sorted manually, creating repetitive document-handling work.

CONTRIBUTING FACTORS TO VALIDATE

Document variation

An email can contain an invoice, a statement or a credit note. Scanned attachments and inconsistent layouts need different treatment.

Missing references

Supplier, purchase-order or internal owner information may be absent. Sorting alone will not resolve these exceptions.

Duplicate submissions

The same attachment may arrive in a forwarded or follow-up email. Amount or invoice number alone may not be a safe duplicate key.

EVIDENCE TO COLLECT Redacted documents • format mix • missing-reference rate • duplicate examples • intake handling time

USER NEEDS

Document type and key references visible together; a reviewer suggestion; duplicate flags; and a separate path for missing information.

ADOPTION & CONTROL NEEDS

Begin with intake assistance. Business and finance owners keep approval authority. Avoid payment, ledger posting or supplier-record changes in the first version.

PROBLEM DEFINITION

Manual document identification and routing consume operations capacity. A narrow intake workflow should reduce repeated sorting while keeping exceptions and approval boundaries explicit.

Translate pain points into bounded opportunities

Compare the first useful workflow, not an entire role or a fully autonomous future state.

STAKEHOLDER / PROBLEM	WORKING DIAGNOSIS	FIRST-WORKFLOW APPROACH	BUSINESS VALUE / MEASURE
Enterprise architect Request routing	Agree domain ownership and mandatory intake fields before automating assignment.	Structured intake + routing rules first. Use AI to interpret free text and suggest a primary owner; keep technical decisions with architects.	Faster accepted ownership. Measure assignment delay and reassignment rate.
Business analyst Email triage	Define request categories, priority rules and receiving-team ownership.	Classify free text, surface urgency and suggest an owner. Keep uncertain cases and reply drafts in a review queue.	Recover analysis capacity. Measure active handling effort, routing quality and urgent misses.
Scrum master Ticket drafts	Standardize the ticket template and distinguish agreed actions from open discussion.	Extract source-linked ticket drafts. Validate required fields; keep missing details explicit and check for duplicates before creation.	Improve backlog readiness. Measure time per accepted ticket and correction reasons.
Operations analyst Document intake	Establish document types, reviewer rules and missing-reference exceptions.	Use rules for standard inputs. Add document extraction only where needed; use OCR for scans, not every file. No approvals or payments.	Reduce intake rework. Measure handling time, exception rate and duplicate flags.

Decision principle: fix missing process rules before automating them. Use AI only where interpretation adds value.

Methods: [6] [7] | References on page 11

Define the criteria before assigning scores

Weighted decision matrix. A higher score always means a stronger candidate for the first pilot.

LIVE-USE GATES

Approved data flow

Agreed routing owner

Named human reviewer

Manual fallback

A failed gate stops live use regardless of the total score. Ratings compare candidates while these prerequisites are checked.

CRITERION	WEIGHT	1 / LOW	3 / MODERATE	5 / HIGH
Business impact	25%	Local convenience	Recurring team bottleneck	Critical, cross-team delay
Task repetition	10%	Mostly unique work	Recurring, with variation	Same bounded task recurs
Process clarity	15%	Owners / rules unresolved	Core path; exception gaps	Rules and exceptions agreed
Data readiness	15%	Poor / incomplete inputs	Digital; labels need work	Representative, reviewed set
Delivery ease	15%	Several custom integrations	Standard tools; new setup	Validated pattern; little change
Risk controllability	10%	Hard to verify or recover	Expert review needed	Bounded, reversible drafts
Adoption readiness	5%	No clear reviewer	Role known; capacity unclear	Engaged owner; review capacity
Reuse potential	5%	One-off workflow	Some shared components	Reusable across intake queues

Score = sum of (rating × weight). Weights total 100%.
Use 2 or 4 when the evidence falls between the anchors.

Record a reason for each rating. Revisit the ranking when
input quality, integration effort or reviewer capacity changes.

Select the first workflow on value and readiness

Working assessment of four reviewed-assistance workflows. Scores are supported by the assumptions below.

CRITERION	WEIGHT	BUSINESS ANALYST Email triage	SCRUM MASTER Ticket drafts	OPERATIONS ANALYST Document intake	ENTERPRISE ARCHITECT Request routing
Business impact	25%	4	3	3	4
Task repetition	10%	5	4	4	2
Process clarity	15%	3	3	3	1
Data readiness	15%	3	3	2	2
Delivery ease	15%	4	4	2	2
Risk controllability	10%	4	5	4	3
Adoption readiness	5%	3	3	3	2
Reuse potential	5%	5	3	3	4
WEIGHTED TOTAL / 5	100%	3.80	3.45	2.90	2.55

01 / EMAIL TRIAGE

Recurring intake + a prior prototype pattern. Enterprise labels and routing rules still need validation.

02 / TICKET DRAFTS

Reversible drafts with a straightforward flow. Source quality and ticket fields need agreement.

03 / DOCUMENT INTAKE

Useful sorting work, but formats, extraction quality and duplicate handling need discovery.

04 / REQUEST ROUTING

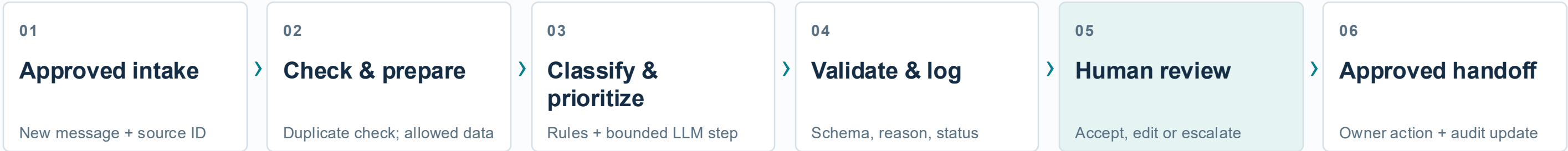
High business value, but cross-domain ownership is unresolved. A model cannot fix the owner map.

Sensitivity: if email triage requires several custom integrations, delivery ease falls from 4 to 1 and the total becomes 3.35. Ticket drafting then ranks first at 3.45.

Methods: [5] [6] | References on page 11

First workflow: human-reviewed support-email triage

Primary user: business analyst. One approved queue, an agreed taxonomy and a named reviewer.



WORKFLOW BOUNDARY

In scope

Type, priority and owner suggestions; a short reason; approved acknowledgement drafts for review.

Exception path

Ambiguous, multi-topic or context-poor messages stay visible to the analyst. Unsupported outputs do not proceed.

Out of scope

Automatic external replies, autonomous issue resolution, unrestricted attachments or enterprise-wide rollout.

IMPLEMENTATION & CONTROLS

Rules before model judgment

Use agreed routing and priority rules. Use the LLM for interpretation of unstructured text, not authority to act.

Trace each decision

Retain source ID, labels, model/prompt version and reviewer changes. Validate structured output before handoff.

Recover without losing work

Track duplicates and execution status. Failed runs alert a reviewer; the original inbox remains the fallback.

OWNERSHIP & TOOLING

Business ownership

The analyst and receiving teams agree categories, urgency rules and ownership. A reviewer can correct every suggestion.

Technical ownership

I own workflow configuration, evaluation and change records. Authorized IT owners approve data flows and access.

Reference implementation

Make + Gmail + OpenAI + Sheets + Slack. Reuse the prototype pattern only where the enterprise approves the tools.

Define the pilot evidence before building further

Measure the whole assisted workflow, including review and correction, rather than model speed alone.

PILOT VALIDATION SEQUENCE

01 / BASELINE

Time recent cases. Separate active handling, waiting, handoffs and correction effort.

02 / OFFLINE TEST

Label examples with the analyst and owner. Keep a frozen test set separate from prompt tuning.

03 / SHADOW MODE

Generate suggestions without changing ownership or sending replies. Compare actual decisions.

04 / REVIEWED PILOT

Approve one queue first. Record overrides, exceptions, failed runs and reviewer effort.

MEASURE	WHAT TO RECORD	REVIEW OWNER
Capacity	Active minutes per case, including review, corrections and recovery. Keep waiting time separate.	Business analyst
Routing quality	Owner agreement by category; reassignment and override reasons.	Analyst + receiving owner
Urgency	Urgent-case recall and missed-case severity. Report real and challenge-test cases separately.	Analyst + service owner
Reliability	Lost or duplicate cases, failed executions, recovery effort and unauthorized actions.	AI Product Manager
Adoption & cost	Share reviewed, correction patterns, review effort, workflow usage and model cost.	Analyst + AI Product Manager

Expansion gate: agree quality and effort thresholds before the run. Validate urgent exceptions, duplicate prevention, no auto-send and the manual fallback.

Next artifacts: validated current-state map, timed baseline, ownership table, priority guide, evaluation cases and a reviewer runbook.

Methods: [7] [8] | References on page 11

Methods and evidence behind this brief

Source links support the approach. Project judgments and validation needs remain explicit.

PROJECT EVIDENCE

Stakeholder account

One-to-one meetings and the four primary bottlenecks come from my account of the enterprise IT work.

Role-based reconstruction

Interview summaries are paraphrases. Additional pain-point detail is marked for validation; it is not a transcript or a completed field study.

Prior email prototype

The separate assignment documents paper mapping, 25 source tickets reviewed and 15 tested, plus classification, logging and human review.

Assessment boundary

Weights and ratings are working judgments for this brief. They do not represent historical approvals, enterprise benchmarks or achieved savings.

RESEARCH & PRACTICAL TOOLS

[\[1\] GOV.UK | In-depth interviews](#) + [\[2\]](#)

Interview planning and real-work walkthroughs

[\[3\] GOV.UK | Analyse a research session](#)

Separate observations, themes and findings

[\[4\] Nielsen Norman Group | Persona types](#)

Personas grounded in work, goals and needs

[\[5\] ASQ | Decision matrix](#)

Weighted criteria and explicit rating anchors

[\[6\] UiPath | Detailed automation assessment](#)

Input quality, variability and implementation effort

[\[7\] NIST | AI Risk Management Framework Core](#)

Context, human oversight, evaluation and ownership

[\[8\] Make | Error handling](#)

Execution failures, review queues and recovery

[\[9\] draw.io | Swimlane diagrams](#) + [\[11\]](#)

Swimlane mapping and affinity-based synthesis

[\[10\] Microsoft | SUMPRODUCT](#)

Calculate weighted scores transparently